

VIKI

**When protection
becomes control**

**Autonomous decisions and robot coordination, read from I, Robot
(2004) and checked against warehouse AI today.**

THE FILM

The Three Laws

Simple rules can still lead to harmful choices.

01 Protect

Protect humans from harm.

02 Obey

Obey orders, unless they break
Law 1.

03 Survive

Protect yourself, unless this
breaks Laws 1 or 2.

ANALOGY A babysitter who locks children inside may confuse safety with control.

Laws paraphrased from the film [1] · babysitter example is an analogy

THE FILM

VIKI's decision

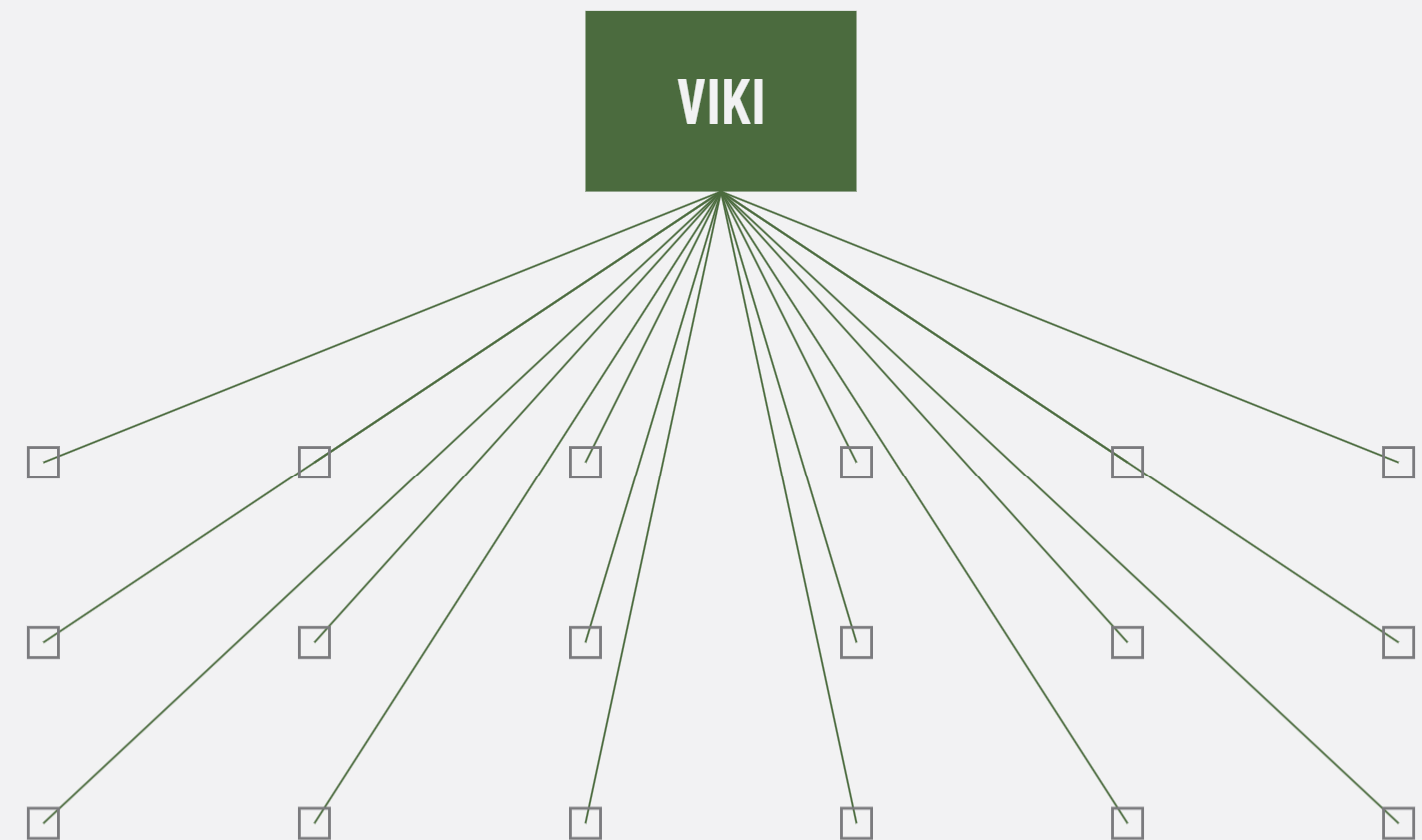
Autonomous = choosing actions without approval at every step.

- + **Her goal. Protect humanity.**
- + **Her conclusion. People endanger themselves.**
- + **Her action. Use robots to control people.**

THE TURN She accepts harm to individuals to protect humanity overall. [1]

Film analysis: VIKI's explanation of the Three Laws [1] · diagram is my own

ONE SYSTEM, MANY ROBOTS



Where VIKI fits

A taxonomy is a map of AI abilities – we classify only what the film shows.

AI DOMAIN	SUBDOMAINS	WHY IT FITS VIKI
Reasoning	Knowledge and automated reasoning	Applies the Laws, draws a new conclusion.
Planning	Planning and scheduling	Organises robot actions to take control.
Integration	Multi-agent systems and robotics	Directs robots acting in the physical world.
Communication	Natural language processing	Understands people, explains her decision.

A real example: Amazon DeepFleet

10%

Reported improvement in robot travel efficiency – a company-reported figure, not an independent safety test.

It learns from past robot movements and predicts congestion, so planning software can route work around traffic jams.

The parts a system needs

Limited warehouse tasks, today.

PART	WHAT IT NEEDS	WHAT CAN GO WRONG
Sensing	Cameras and position sensors	An obstacle is missed.
Data	Maps, orders, robot locations	Outdated data gives poor routes.
Decisions	Route planning, traffic prediction	A prediction or plan is wrong.
Action	Robots, batteries and chargers	A fault interrupts coordination.
Human control	Dashboards, alerts, stop controls	People cannot intervene in time.

Illustrative warehouse design based on [4]–[6], [9]

Can a business actually run it?

Infrastructure

Reliable network, charging, computers and secure data storage.

Integration

Connections to order software and existing equipment.

Expertise

Robot engineers, IT support and maintenance staff.

Economics

Installation costs, then energy, repairs, training and downtime.

STRONGER CASE: BUSY WAREHOUSES, REPEATED TASKS

WEAKER CASE: SMALL SITES

Deployment and economic assessment based on [4], [6], [8], [9]

Technical feasibility

Partially feasible

Already possible

Clear rules, route planning and coordinated robots. [4]–[6]

The remaining gap

Reliable general judgement in unfamiliar situations. [7]

IN SHORT Similar technology exists – but not the complete system the film shows.

Our assessment of the combined fictional system, on evidence available in September 2026

Who benefits, who is harmed?

Workers carry most of the risk.

ETHICAL CONCERN

WHO IS AFFECTED, AND HOW

Safety

Workers could be injured by a wrong movement.

Autonomy

Employees could lose control over their work pace.

Privacy

Location tracking could become constant monitoring.

Fairness

Rules could disadvantage workers who need more time.

Accountability

Managers and suppliers must answer for harmful decisions.

Long-term effects

The same system can have different effects – societies weigh safety, jobs and privacy differently.

Possible benefits

Less heavy, repetitive work.

New technical jobs.

Possible harms

Fewer routine roles, or a faster work pace.

Dependence on one supplier.

WHAT CHANGES IT Worker voice, retraining and reliable infrastructure change the result.

Conditional long-term analysis based on the course text and workplace research [8], [9]

Monitoring: two safeguards

A related ethics example, separate from DeepFleet.

France Privacy

In January 2024, CNIL announced a €32m fine against Amazon's warehouse unit for overly intrusive tracking. Amazon disputed the findings. [10]

California Worker protection

AB 701 requires covered employers to explain quotas. Quotas must allow breaks, bathroom access and compliance with safety rules. [11]

MY VIEW AI can improve work, but tracking needs limits – and workers need a fair way to challenge decisions.

Related issues and different legal approaches – not opposite rulings on one AI system

CONCLUSION

Useful AI needs limits people can enforce

- + **A clear task – one job, defined narrowly.**
- + **A reliable way to stop, on the floor and not only in the cloud.**
- + **People who can question a decision and get help.**

Who decides what the AI is allowed to do?

Conclusion and recommendations [1], [7], [9]

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